A NATION AT STAKE

As the line between online gaming and gambling blurs, millions of Indians grapple with addiction, debt and fraud while the government scrambles to rein in a booming yet chaotic industry

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Photo illustration by NILANJAN DAS / AI

It's **a sweltering afternoon in Brahimpur in east Uttar Pradesh's Sultanpur district,** but 35-year-old farmer Surya Pratap Singh seems oblivious to it. He is sitting beneath a neem tree, furiously tapping his phone screen. Around him, a few plastic chairs and a charpoy make up what is probably Brahimpur gram sabha's unofficial gaming lounge. The game of choice isn't played with dice or cards, it's all digital instead, be it ludo, fantasy cricket or online rummy. The stakes? They are very real. "This has been our routine for years," says Surya Pratap. "No matter what I'm doing, I have to play. I need Rs 2,000-3,000 every day just to get by.... I know I won't win. But I cannot stop."

Surya Pratap's addiction has cost him not just money but peace of mind, familial ties and self-esteem too. He has logged some 19,500 games on his app, often wagering thousands in a single round. On one particularly devastating day, he lost Rs 1.5 lakh, convinced that he was about to win it all back. "I thought I was having a heart attack," he recalls.

Surya Pratap is but one symptom of the digital gambling epidemic sweeping through India—from rural Uttar Pradesh to urban Hyderabad, from farmers to professionals, from students to pensioners—driven by smartphones, cheap data, quick online payments and the 'gamification' of aspiration. According to a report by WinZO Games and the Interactive Entertainment and Innovation Council (IEIC), India's gaming market stood at $3.7 billion (Rs 31,500 crore) in 2024 and is projected to surge to $9.1 billion (Rs 78,000 crore) by 2029, growing at a blistering compound annual growth rate of 19.6 per cent. A separate estimate by Statista Market Insights puts India's online sports betting market alone at $2.19 billion (Rs 18,700 crore) in 2025. India now accounts for over 20 per cent of global gaming users and around 8.6 billion app downloads, more than the next two biggest markets—the US and Brazil—combined. The real driver of this growth? The phenomenon of Real Money

$3.7 BILLION
Size of India's online gaming market, projected to reach $9.1 bn by 2029

86 PER CENT
Real money gaming's contribution to total revenue in India's gaming market

180 MILLION
No. of Indian users in $2 billion fantasy sports segment